Sleeping Sickness and Andrew

By Julia Serano and Andrea Gibson

Sleeping Sickness

in the name of the father

the son

and the holy spirit

amen

that's how it begins

my nights are spent

composing insomniac open letters to you

two-hour-long monologues

that end in exhaustion

and sometimes in the middle of my day

i'll remember that i fell asleep

before ending my previous night's prayer

with a proper amen

and i'll wonder whether my channel to you is still open

my every word an invocation

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the sounds of my atari games

little league practice

and eighth grade history class

becoming the annoying background noise of heaven

INTRODUCTION

"Are transgender people allowed to pray?" If one prays for strength, for knowledge, for forgiveness, for help in forgiving, for clarification, for peace; then not only are transgender people "allowed" to pray, they are blessed by praying. And so are we all.

When Julia Serano was 12, she attended a Catholic school and lived in daily fear of rejection by a vengeful God who she had been taught would cast sinners into the pit of hell. Julia's sin? She had been born a boy, but in her heart knew that she was a girl. She prayed and begged for forgiveness.

Sleeping Sickness by Julia Serano

. . . maybe forgetting to say amen

makes my life one long continuous prayer

and if so, then you were there that afternoon

when i tucked my penis tightly behind my legs

just to see what i'd look like without it

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when i wrapped bedroom curtains around my body
like a prom dress
turned tattered shoelaces
into necklaces and bracelets
and you were there later that same night
when i began another prayer within a prayer
to once again beg for your forgiveness

wanting to be a girl
never came up in CCD or sunday mass
and it's not covered in the ten commandments
but from everything the nuns and priests taught me
about you
i know that you do not approve
and when i turn to your holy words
to look for anything that might shed some light
onto whatever this is that i'm going through
i keep returning to the same story
the one about abraham
and how you commanded him to sacrifice his son to you
stopping the blade only seconds before

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he actually went through with it
and forgive me father
for i can't help but think
that that was a ***** up thing to do

and maybe i'm like abraham
and this is just another one of your tests
maybe you put girl thoughts
into the heads of twelve-year-old boys
just to see how they'll react
maybe i'm an experiment
and you're up in heaven looking down on me
taking notes as i tear myself apart in self-hatred
tossing and turning in bed
as if acting out my inevitable burning in hell
and at first
my sins made me even more devout
i'd lie awake each night
clutching the glow-in-the-dark rosary beads
that my grandmother gave me
repeating the words that i once heard her say

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"blessed are those who have not seen yet believe"
and i want to believe
but more and more it just feels
like you're torturing me
and i'm doing the best that i can
to plug up all the holes
in this disintegrating dam
as my brain bleeds rivers of bad thoughts
that pour out of my mouth and hands
like wounds that won't clot
and i can't understand
why you won't help
when i've asked you over and over again
to please either turn me into a girl
or else make these thoughts stop

the nuns say that you answer all prayers
it's just that sometimes the answer is no
well, i'm tired of praying to a god
who only offers me
thou shalt not's

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i'm tired from lack of sleep
from keeping secrets
that burn so much that they hollow me out
i am tired of hurting so much
that sometimes i pray
that i don't wake up
so forgive me father for i have sinned
i have dared to share
all of myself with you
forcing you to watch
one long sacrilegious prayer
within a prayer
within a prayer
within a prayer
like a serpent swallowing its own soul
like a serpent swallowing itself whole
and maybe tonight
i'll finally be cured of this sleeping sickness
because the last few years
of living in absolute shame
and unbelievable pain

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has made me fearless enough to finally say

amen.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Julia Serano
Book: Word Warriors
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TRANSITION

Poet Andrea Gibson also struggled with gender identity as she was growing up. For her the issue isn't male OR female . . . but perhaps some category in between. She concludes that the best thing a person can do for the world is be themselves, honestly, openly -- brave and beautiful. We are all different. Not one of us the same, but we all share a common bond: we want to be loved. The only place to start is with the self. Love yourself first, share the beauty. She shares her beauty with us in "Andrew" by Andrea Gibson.

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Andrew

Would tug at the crotch of my pants the way only pubescent boys do

When I was a kid I would sometimes secretly call myself Andrew

Ran around pounding on my bare chest like Tarzan

It's not that I thought I'd grow up to be a man

I just never thought I'd grow up to be a woman either

From what I could tell neither of those categories fit me

But believe me I knew from a very young age never to say

Hey Dad, this Adam or Eve thing isn't really working for me

I mean what about all the kinds of people in-between?

In the third grade Lynette Lions asked me where all my Barbies were

I lied and told her I got in trouble so my mom took 'em away

I didn't dare say Barbie sucks, Lynette!

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And for that matter, Timmy, so does G.I. Joe

I want to grow into something none of us has ever seen before

And gender is just one of the ways we're boxed and labeled

Before we're ever able to speak who we dream we are

Who believe we'll become

Like drum beats forever changing their rhythm

I am living today as someone I had not yet become yesterday

And tonight I will borrow only pieces of who I was today

To carry with me tomorrow

No, I'm not gay

No, I'm not straight

I'm sure as **** not bisexual, damn it!

I am whatever I am when I am it

Loving whoever you are when the stars shine

And whoever you'll be when the sun rises

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Yes, I like girls

Yes, I like boys

Yes, I like boys who like boys

I like girls . . .

Girls who don't call themselves girls

Crew cuts or curls and that really bad hair phase in between

Tell me we'll be naming our children "Beautiful" and nothing else

Tell Barbie she can go now

Tell GI Joe to put his gun down

And find a boyfriend or a girlfriend or a girl-boy-friend

GI Joe just needs a friend

I mean, he's plastic and not even the kind of plastic that bends

I want to bend in a thousand directions

Like the sun does, like love does, like time stopped

So the hands of the clock could hold each other

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Like I held these words for too many years on the tip of my tongue

I am my mother's daughter

I am midnight sun

You can find me on the moon waxing and waning

My heart full of petals, every single one begging

"Love me, love me, love me

Whoever I am

Whoever I become

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Andrea Gibson
Book: The Madness Vase
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